

Family Relationships and Values

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The question: What is a family in Madhyasth Darshan, why is it the first place where values become livable, and how are its relationships recognised and their values fulfilled?

This study sets out the Madhyasth Darshan account of the family: what makes a family a family, which relationships constitute it, how those relationships are recognised, which values are inherent in them, and why the darshan treats the family rather than the individual or the state as the unit at which need is assessed and prosperity becomes definable.

The treatment here is **expository within Madhyasth Darshan**. Unlike most studies in this collection it does not run a parallel comparison with Advaita Vedanta, modern Western philosophy, and the sciences. The darshan's claims about family are unusually specific — a definite set of relationships, a definite list of values, a definite locus for assessing need — and stating them accurately is a substantial task on its own. Comparison with modern family sociology, care ethics, and household economics is left to a later revision or to a companion study; [Axiology Value Theory](#) §§3, 5 already places the underlying theory of value against Western axiology, and [Human Behavior and Society](#) and [How Undivided Society Is Established](#) carry the comparison at social scale. §2 below states the open problems in the darshan's own account, so the exposition is not left uncriticised.

Two studies supply what this one assumes. [Axiology Value Theory](#) establishes what a value is, the distinction between relationship and association, and the classes of value including the nine established values (§§1.1, 1.6–1.9). [How Undivided Society Is Established](#) §5.2 argues from the family outward to undivided society. The present study works in the other direction: inward, at the scale where relationships are actually lived.

Standpoint and scope

These studies are written from the standpoint of a **scientist and technologist** — someone trained to graduate-level **physics and mathematics**, at home with contemporary cosmology, quantum theory, conservation laws, and the logic of formal models.

From that background, a familiar picture is hard to avoid: **the family looks like a contingent social arrangement** — an evolved reproductive strategy, an economic household, a bundle of negotiated preferences that varies with culture and law and carries no structure of its own. Modern social science is powerful on variation, measurement, and causal inference; yet what makes a relationship a relationship rather than an arrangement, and whether anything is owed within one independently of what the parties have agreed, remain unresolved.

The standpoint taken here does not treat those questions as settled in favour of the view that family structure is merely conventional.

The work begins where that picture leaves open questions — and asks whether Madhyasth Darshan offers a coherent alternative worth examining seriously. Across this collection the method is to read the primary texts carefully, state what follows from the darshan itself, and compare it in parallel with **physics and the natural and social sciences**, **Advaita Vedanta**, and **modern Western philosophy** (here, the ethics of care, family sociology, and household economics). Physics and mathematics are **one leg** of that comparison, not the only one. The aim is rigorous comparative understanding — testing definitions, internal consistency, and fit with public knowledge — not persuasion or devotional endorsement. This particular study takes the expository half of that task and defers the comparative half, for the reason given above.

These topical studies state the philosophy in clear, checkable prose first. A separate formal mathematical treatment may follow once the definitions and relations are stable across the studies; this paper does not assume or require that treatment.

1. The Madhyasth Darshan Answer

Madhyasth Darshan holds that a family is not primarily a household, a lineage, or an affectionate arrangement. It is the first grouping in which relationships with predetermined expectations are lived continuously, and therefore the first place where values can be recognised, fulfilled, evaluated, and found mutually satisfying. Everything the darshan says about society is built from that, which is why it treats the family as the first tier of orderliness rather than as a private matter preceding public life.

1.1 What a family is

The definition is minimal and deliberately continuous with larger groupings:

“More than one human coming together or becoming organised is referred to as a family, community, or undivided society.”

— MVD, p. 55

Nothing here appeals to kinship, cohabitation, or reproduction. What distinguishes a family from a community or an undivided society is scale and immediacy, not kind — the same account of mutuality runs through all three. MVD’s related definition of behaviour makes the point from the other side: behaviour is the utilisation of effort where more than one human comes together (MVD, p. 33). Family is the smallest scale at which behaviour, in this technical sense, exists at all.

Two consequences follow immediately. First, the darshan cannot treat the family as a natural given that precedes evaluation; a family is as humane as its relationships are recognised and its values fulfilled. Second, it cannot treat the family as a private zone exempt from the stan-

dards applied to society, since the standards are the same standards. MVD accordingly lists five statuses of the human being — individual, family, society, nation, and world — as one graded series (MVD, p. 18).

1.2 Relationship, not association

The darshan’s decisive move is to distinguish two kinds of mutuality by the character of their expectations. A relationship (*sambandh*) is a mutuality whose expectations are predetermined in the sense of completeness; an association (*sampark*) is a mutuality whose expectations are voluntary (MVD, pp. 61–62). [Axiology Value Theory](#) §1.6 develops the distinction and its consequences for value theory.

Applied to the family, the claim is strong and easy to understate. What a parent owes a child, on this account, is not settled by what the parent has undertaken, what the local law requires, or what the two have negotiated. It is given with the relationship. This is what allows the darshan to say that a family can fail without either party recognising the failure, and it is what makes evaluation of a family relationship a question with an answer rather than a clash of preferences.

It also means that association is not a defective family relationship but a different thing. Friendships, working arrangements, and neighbourly dealings in which the parties settle what they expect of each other are associations in this vocabulary, and they carry value too — no contact or relationship is devoid of value (KD, p. 20). The distinction concerns where the expectation comes from, not how much the mutuality matters.

1.3 The relationships that constitute a family

The set is enumerated rather than left open:

“Relationships are in the form of father-mother and son-daughter, brother-sister, husband-wife, master-associate, guru-disciple, friends, and orderliness relationships.”

— MVD, p. 190

Four of the seven are ordinarily internal to a family, and the remaining three reach outward from it.

Relationship	Where it is lived	What it contributes to family living
Father-mother and son-daughter	Within the family	Nurturing and protection across generations
Brother-sister	Within the family	Mutual assurance among equals of one generation

Relationship	Where it is lived	What it contributes to family living
Husband-wife	Within the family	Faithfulness, and the continuity of the household itself
<i>Guru</i> and disciple	Within and beyond	Transmission of understanding, beginning with parents as first teachers
Master and associate	Beyond the family	Work, production, and earning brought back into family living
Friends	Beyond the family	Complementary assistance without hierarchy
Orderliness	Beyond and around	The family's participation in society and universal orderliness

That one seven-fold set covers relations inside and outside the family is itself the darshan's position: the family is not governed by a separate morality of intimacy. The values inherent in a relationship do not change because the relationship happens to be domestic.

1.4 Recognition by purpose

Values do not flow from a relationship until the relationship is recognised, and the darshan holds that a relationship is recognised through its purpose. JV states the principle and applies it to the family directly:

“The study of relationships is guided by their respective purposes; nurturing defines the mother-child relationship, while protection characterises the father-child relationship.”

— JV, p. 56

“The conditions and methods of recognising relationships arise from their intended purposes. Children recognise ‘mother’ as the nurturer. The provider of protection is known as ‘father’. The source of knowledge and guidance is referred to as ‘guru’, and the source of curiosity and learning is known as ‘disciple’.”

— JV, p. 84

The definitions are functional in a specific sense: they name what the relationship is *for*, not what biology or law assigns. Someone recognised as nurturer is recognised as mother in this vocabulary. The texts reviewed here do not draw out what that implies for households whose composition does not match the nomenclature, which §2.3 records as an open problem rather than resolving.

JV also enumerates what relationships are for, in an order of priority:

“...in reality, our relationships are meant first for evidencing comprehensive resolution, second for nurturing, third for protection, fourth for usefulness and complementariness, fifth for right-use, and sixth for purposeful-use. Authenticity is the highest priority in relationships.”

— JV, p. 108

Purpose	What it asks of a family relationship
Evidencing comprehensive resolution	That living together makes understanding evident, not merely tolerable
Nurturing	That growth of body and <i>jeevan</i> is actively provided for
Protection	That security is furnished without domination
Usefulness and complementariness	That each member’s capacities complete the others’
Right-use	That body, mind, and wealth are used for what they are for
Purposeful-use	That resources and effort serve the family’s assessed purposes

Resolution comes first and nurturing second. A family that provides materially while leaving its members confused about how to live has not met the first purpose, and the darshan’s ordering makes that a failure rather than a partial success.

1.5 What recognition replaces

The account gains its edge from what it displaces. JV names the criteria by which relationships are ordinarily identified and rejects them:

“Traditionally, we identify relationships based on power, wealth, intelligence, or age.”

— JV, p. 108

It then names the two motives it takes to be doing the real work in unrecognised relationships:

“Until now, we recognised relationships based on fear and temptation, but now we prioritise values, evaluation, resolution, and prosperity. Fear and temptation are not values, so their evaluation is meaningless.”

— JV, p. 109

This is the darshan's diagnosis of family dysfunction, and it is not primarily about conflict or scarcity. A family ordered by power, seniority, or earning capacity may be perfectly stable and still, on this account, not have recognised its relationships at all — because what holds it together is leverage rather than purpose. The same holds for families held together by fear of consequences or by expectation of advantage. Since fear and temptation are not values, no quantity of them can be evaluated as value-fulfilment, and the arrangement they sustain cannot yield mutual satisfaction.

The claim that follows is checkable in a family's own experience: where relationships are not recognised, mistakes are inevitable, and once they are recognised humans no longer make mistakes in those contexts (JV, p. 56). Taken as stated this is very strong, and §2.1 asks what it can reasonably mean.

1.6 The nine established values in family living

The values inherent in relationships are named and defined. [Axiology Value Theory](#) §1.7 gives the list and its sources; what matters here is how each bears on family living.

Value	Definition in the sources	Where it is first lived
Care (<i>mamta</i>)	Nurturing and protecting with the pinnacle of affinity; accepting the other as an image of oneself (MVD, p. 339)	Parent to infant; the paradigm case of unearned value
Guidance (<i>vatsalya</i>)	Continuity of nurturing and protection for comprehensive resolution (MVD, p. 332)	Parent and elder sibling to child
Trust (<i>vishwas</i>)	Fulfilling the inherent expectation of values in mutuality (MVD, pp. 73, 336)	Between spouses, and between generations
Affection (<i>sneha</i>)	Absence of resistance in just behaviour; wilful meeting in, by, and for satisfaction (MVD, pp. 73, 340)	Among siblings and spouses
Gratitude (<i>kritagyata</i>)	Acceptance of inspiration and support for advancement and awakening (MVD, pp. 37, 335)	Child to parent and teacher; the value the others follow from
Glory (<i>gaurav</i>)	Emulation and endeavour embraced without resistance (MVD, pp. 37, 335)	Younger to elder, where the elder is worth emulating
Love (<i>prem</i>)	Realisation of the complete; the combined expression of kindness, grace, and compassion (MVD, pp. 317, 331)	The family as a whole, when the rest are in place
Reverence (<i>shraddha</i>)	Movement towards righteousness and conduct completeness (MVD, pp. 326, 332)	Disciple to <i>guru</i> , including parents as first teachers

Value	Definition in the sources	Where it is first lived
Respect (<i>samman</i>)	Acceptance of personality and talent, and its balanced exposition (MVD, p. 340)	Between spouses and between generations

Three features matter for family life specifically. None of the definitions is affective: each names an activity or an acceptance whose success conditions lie in the relationship rather than in how warmly a member feels. Trust is defined as *fulfilment*, so a family in which everyone feels confident while expectations go unmet does not have trust in this sense. And love sits at the far end of the list rather than the beginning — it is the realisation of the complete, which makes it the outcome of the other values rather than the emotion that founds a family.

The values are not to be acquired from outside. JV holds that they are inherent in *jeevan* and are deployed when relationships are recognised, and gives the family's own example: when a mother has recognised her child, motherly care begins to surge by itself, needing no plan (JV, p. 138). The corresponding claim about failure is equally direct — where relationships are not recognised, there is no flow of values (JV, p. 55).

1.7 Gratitude first

The nine are ordered by dependence, and the family is where the ordering is visible. JV states that gratitude comes first and that with gratitude the other values begin to manifest, with affection, love, and trust developing after it (JV, p. 108). MVD gives the sequence as a chain:

“Gratitude leads to glory, glory leads to simplicity, simplicity leads to effortlessness, effortlessness leads to humaneness, humaneness leads to coexistence, and gratitude arises in, by, and for coexistence.”

— MVD, p. 38

Gratitude is defined as acceptance of inspiration and support for advancement and awakening (MVD, p. 37), and its opposite, ingratitude, as disregarding support received (MVD, p. 38). In a family this has an obvious application and an unobvious one. Obviously, a child's recognition of what has been provided is where value-fulfilment starts. Less obviously, the chain runs through glory — emulation embraced without resistance — which makes the elder generation's conduct, not its authority, the mechanism by which values pass down. A parent who cannot be emulated without resistance has broken the chain at its second link, whatever the child's obligations.

1.8 Fulfilment, evaluation, and mutual satisfaction

Recognition is only the first of four steps. The complete activity is recognition of relationships, fulfilling of values, evaluation, and mutual satisfaction, which the darshan identifies

with justice (MVD, p. 336). Family living is where the sequence runs most often and most consequentially.

Each step can fail on its own. A member may not recognise that a relationship is present; may recognise it and lack the capacity, ability, or receptivity to fulfil it; may fulfil it and evaluate the result wrongly; or may reach satisfaction on one side only. The mediating conditions matter more in families than anywhere else, because capacity is unequally distributed by age, health, and circumstance — an eight-year-old and a grandparent are held to the same values but not to the same capacity for fulfilling them.

Mutual satisfaction is the terminus, and its mutuality does real work. Satisfaction on one side is not a partial result but a failure of the sequence, which is what blocks reading the darshan's account of family as an ethic of self-sacrifice. A member who fulfils values while remaining unsatisfied has not completed justice in the family, on this account, and neither has the family.

1.9 Character in the family

Humane conduct is the combined form of values, character, and ethics (JV, p. 55), and the darshan's account of character is stated in three concrete terms that are substantially about family living: righteous wealth, marital faithfulness, and kindness in work and behaviour (JV, p. 55). Their negations are named as crime:

“Crime (apradh): - Ill-gotten wealth, adultery, and hurtful work & behaviour to others, constitute crime.”

— MVD, p. 60

MVD repeats the triad as the content of just behaviour (MVD, p. 102) and makes it the determinant of societal balance: balance or imbalance depends on behaviour of righteous or ill-gotten wealth, marital faithfulness or adultery, and conduct based on kindness or malice (MVD, p. 189). Two of the three are directly domestic, and the third is not confined to strangers.

The reasoning behind marital faithfulness here is worth stating precisely, because it is not primarily a purity claim. The spousal relationship is one whose expectations are predetermined (§1.2); faithfulness is the fulfilment of that expectation, and adultery is its breach — a failure of value-fulfilment in a definite relationship rather than the violation of a taboo. On the same logic, righteous wealth is not asceticism but the condition under which what a family uses can be evaluated at all, since resources obtained by breaching other relationships cannot be rightly used within this one.

1.10 Need is determined by a wise family

The most distinctive claim in the darshan's treatment of family concerns who assesses need:

“Needs (avashyakta): - The strong desire for adequate resources, determined by a wise family, for fulfilling the values itself is the need. This is meant for bodily nourishment-protection, and societal participation.”

— MVD, p. 56

Three things are built into this definition. Need is relative to *value-fulfilment*, not to desire or to a subsistence minimum. Its scope is bodily nourishment and protection together with societal participation, so it is neither merely biological nor open-ended. And the assessing unit is neither the individual nor the state but the **wise family** — wise, not any family as it happens to be.

This is why the family is indispensable to the darshan’s economics rather than incidental to it. An individual assessing need alone has no check on comparison and insecurity; a state assessing need for others cannot know what value-fulfilment requires in a particular household. The family is small enough to know its own case and large enough that the assessment is not one person’s appetite. MVD locates social responsibility at the same scale: the evidence of social responsibility becomes apparent in every wise family living with resolution and prosperity, which leads to progressively recognising the whole of humankind as one unit (MVD, p. 253).

The qualifier carries the weight, and the darshan is explicit that it is doing so. A family ordered by power, fear, or temptation (§1.5) is not a wise family and its assessment of need is not authoritative. What makes a family wise is what makes anything else so — awakening evidenced in recognition, fulfilment, and evaluation. §2.2 asks whether this can be established without circularity.

1.11 Prosperity at family scale

Prosperity is defined twice, and the two definitions are not in competition:

“Prosperity (samriddhi): - The lack of the sentiment of lacking itself is prosperity.”

— MVD, p. 72

“Prosperity (samriddhi): - Production more than needs is prosperity.”

— MVD, p. 342

The first names the state, the second its condition. Because need has already been fixed by the wise family’s assessment (§1.10), “more than needs” is a determinate quantity rather than a receding target, and the sentiment of lacking can therefore actually cease. SB states the same at family scale — prosperity through production in excess of needs within a wise family (SB, p. 223) — and MVD adds that the realisation of prosperity is self-reliance (MVD, p. 342).

This is where the darshan’s account of family does argumentative work that no other scale can do for it. Prosperity is not definable for an individual, because an individual’s needs are

not assessed against the fulfilment of relationships; and it is not definable for a state, because aggregate production says nothing about whether any household has enough. It becomes definable exactly where need is assessed. Prosperity in the family is correspondingly one of the four human goals, alongside resolution in the individual, fearlessness in society, and coexistence in universal orderliness ([Axiology Value Theory](#) §1.4).

1.12 Education and *sanskar* begin in the family

The family is where understanding is transmitted before any institution reaches the child. JV states the direction of effect in both senses: humane education and *sanskar* practised with children changes their homes and families in turn (JV, p. 60). MVD makes parents structurally necessary rather than merely helpful:

“The development of a successful education-sanskar method is possible only when the educational procedure, teachers, parents, and study are aligned. This paves the way for gratitude and coexistence.”

— MVD, p. 270

Sanskar is the mechanism. It names acceptances towards completeness and the knowledge and tendencies carried forward for evidencing, and MVD calls it the cause of awakening of the sentient aspect (MVD, p. 90), divided into *susanskar* under awakening and *kusanskar* under delusion (MVD, p. 315). [Axiology Value Theory](#) §1.16 sets out the circuit by which conduct deepens or entrenches understanding.

In the family this cuts both ways, and the darshan’s own logic requires saying so. A household whose conduct is ordered by fear and temptation transmits *kusanskar* by exactly the mechanism that would otherwise transmit *susanskar*, and it does so more effectively than any curriculum, because the family’s conduct is what the child has to emulate. That is why value education cannot be delivered by schools alone, and also why families reproduce their own errors across generations.

1.13 The natal family as the first field of practice

Nothing in §§1.4–1.8 says where a person’s own capacity for recognition, fulfilment, and evaluation is first exercised. The account fixes it nonetheless, and at the family one is born into. Gratitude stands first in the value sequence (§1.7), and gratitude is acceptance of support received (MVD, p. 37) — which means the first link of the chain can only be located where a person has received before being able to give. *Sanskar* formation begins in the same place and by the same mechanism (§1.12). And MVD’s definition of satiation states the order explicitly: the six merits after the understanding, resolution and prosperity in the family, and then participation in undivided society and universal orderliness (MVD, p. 339). MVD elsewhere describes the movement as progressive — the wise family living with resolution and prosperity is what leads to recognising the whole of humankind as one unit (MVD, p. 253).

The competence at issue is therefore transferable rather than innate. The same four-step activity is exercised on whichever relationships are at hand, and the ones at hand first are parents, siblings, and first teachers. What is practised there is later exercised on master and associate, on friendship, and on orderliness itself. This is also why the darshan can hold that evaluation improves: refinement in *susanskar* follows enlightenment about the human goal and the *jeevan* values (MVD, p. 187), and capacity, ability, and receptivity are conditions that develop rather than fixed endowments (§1.8). Someone who has not recognised the relationships they were born into has not merely neglected those relationships; they have not yet exercised the capacity that recognising any other relationship requires.

Whether this makes family living a spiritual practice needs care with the darshan's vocabulary, because two of its terms pull in opposite directions. MVD and JV use *sadhana* biographically, for the practice Shri A. Nagraj pursued at Amarkantak from 1950 and then moved beyond (MVD, pp. 4, 7; JV, pp. 12, 15), and they gloss *upasana* in its traditional sense as devotional practices towards deities, or ritual (MVD, p. 4; JV, p. 9). Describing family living as *sadhana* in the darshan's own voice would therefore misuse its vocabulary — that word names what the darshan's founder found insufficient.

Manav Karm Darshan redefines the other term, and its redefinition is exactly to the point. Chapter 2 treats *upasana* not as ritual directed at a deity but as the transformation of tendency:

“Upasana itself is the process of refining and transforming the root tendencies. This very study is also the transformation of sanskar and essential nature.”

— KD, p. 30

“Wisdom — that is, the human goal — and jeevan-value — that is, resolution [and] prosperity — is itself the direct result of upasana, in which sociality remains naturally contained.”

— KD, p. 37

The chapter is consistent about the consequences. *Upasana* is in its own nature education and orderliness (KD, p. 42); its chief utility lies in immersion in universal values (KD, p. 35); at the root of all *upasanas* the aim is undivided society and universal orderliness (KD, p. 35); *upasanas* exist only for capacity-for-awakening, not for decline (KD, p. 36); and symbol-directed *upasana* is judged secondary and unsociable to the extent of its incompleteness, because in it the human goal is neither clarified nor attained (KD, p. 42).

Taken with the rest of §1, this leaves no practice standing apart from recognising, fulfilling, and evaluating relationships. If *upasana* is the refinement of root tendencies and *sanskar*, if sociality remains naturally contained in it, and if the first sociality available to anyone is the family they are born into, then the natal family is where *upasana* is performed rather than a domain it is performed alongside. JV makes the displacement explicit by rejecting the substitution it replaces:

“...declares the world to be an illusion and advocates seeking refuge in God as the real father and mother. Yet, no tangible good comes from it. After seeking refuge in the ‘real mother and father,’ no human is found.”

— JV, p. 57

The passage continues that purpose is inherent in all relationships, and that the purpose is resolution, prosperity, fearlessness, and coexistence (JV, p. 57). The literal mother and father, recognised through their purposes, take the place the metaphorical divine ones were given. JV’s parallel verdict on the alternative is that idealism organised around renunciation, non-accumulation, detachment, and devotion has drawn immense courage and dedication and has not produced an undivided society (JV, p. 105).

Two qualifications keep this from overreaching. The sources do not state in any one place that recognition begins in the natal family, nor that family living is *upasana*; both are assembled here from the value sequence, the *sanskara* mechanism, the satiation ordering, and KD’s redefinition, and the Editorial Notes record that. And the ordinal claim sharpens rather than softens the difficulty in §2.8: if the capacity for recognising any relationship is first exercised where one is born, then a natal family transmitting *kusanskara* does not merely fail its own members — it withholds the entry point to everything the darshan asks of them later.

1.14 The family as first tier

The family is not a stage the darshan leaves behind on the way to society. It is the first tier of orderliness and remains a tier:

“The third way is the ten-tier family-based orderliness, wherein family is the first tier, and every individual takes responsibility based on understanding.”

— MVD, p. 161

MVD lists the ten-tier family-based self-governance orderliness alongside the five statuses of the human being (MVD, p. 18), and describes participation as extending from the family order to the world family order (MVD, p. 253). The vocabulary is deliberate: the largest scale is still named a family order, which is the darshan’s way of saying that nothing changes in kind as the scale grows.

Two things follow. Responsibility is not delegated upward — every individual takes responsibility based on understanding, at every tier. And the family is not a private sphere that public institutions may either protect or intrude upon, because it is already the first public institution in the series. [How Undivided Society Is Established](#) §5.2 and [Human Behavior and Society](#) §1.4.3 develop the outward argument; what belongs here is that the outward argument has no separate premises.

1.15 What the darshan does not claim

Three misreadings are worth closing off, since each is easy to fall into from the language of “family order”.

The family is not a larger *jeevan*. It does not acquire a sentience, a will, or an interest of its own over its members; the account of composition in [How Undivided Society Is Established](#) rules this out explicitly. Family values are lived by members, and evaluation is performed by *jeevan*, not by the household.

The family is not the seat of a separate domestic morality. The same seven relationships, the same nine values, and the same four-step justice sequence apply inside it and outside it (§1.3). The darshan has no category of conduct that is acceptable at home and unacceptable elsewhere.

And the family is not an affectionate arrangement whose worth lies in the feelings of its members. The definitions in §1.6 are activities and acceptances, mutual satisfaction is a result rather than a mood, and a family in which everyone feels warmly toward each other while expectations go unfulfilled has not, on this account, achieved value-fulfilment at all.

1.16 Method, evidence, and what Madhyasth Darshan establishes

The claims in §1 do not all warrant the same kind of assent, and separating them matters before §2.

Some are **definitional within the system**: family as more than one human coming together (MVD, p. 55); relationship as predetermined expectation (MVD, p. 62); need as determined by a wise family for fulfilling values (MVD, p. 56); prosperity as production more than needs (MVD, p. 342); character as righteous wealth, marital faithfulness, and kindness (JV, p. 55). These can be assessed for coherence and fruitfulness, not for truth against external evidence.

Some are **structural claims about families** that make contact with ordinary experience and could in principle be checked: that values flow on recognition rather than being cultivated from outside; that gratitude precedes the other values; that families ordered by power, fear, or temptation do not achieve mutual satisfaction; that a household’s conduct transmits *sanskar* more effectively than instruction.

Some are **claims about assessment authority** — that a wise family’s determination of need is authoritative, and that this scale alone makes prosperity definable. These matter most for economics and policy, and they depend entirely on the wisdom qualifier being independently identifiable.

Some are **normative claims about conduct**: marital faithfulness, righteous wealth, and non-injury as the content of character. The darshan derives these from value-fulfilment in definite relationships rather than from command or convention, which is a real derivation within the system and not a neutral one outside it.

2. Open problems for the Madhyasth Darshan account of family

2.1 “No longer make mistakes”

JV states that once relationships are recognised humans no longer make mistakes in those contexts, and that without recognition mistakes are inevitable (JV, p. 56). Read strictly this is false of any family, including families of evidently good understanding: recognition does not confer competence, and the darshan’s own account of capacity, ability, and receptivity (§1.8) says as much. The defensible reading is narrower — that recognition removes a specific class of mistake, namely those arising from misidentifying what a relationship is for. The texts do not distinguish the two readings, and the stronger one is what a sceptical reader meets first.

2.2 Who certifies a wise family?

Need is determined by a wise family (§1.10), and prosperity, right-use, and the family’s authority over its own assessment all rest on that qualifier. But wisdom is evidenced by recognition, fulfilment, and evaluation — the very activities whose adequacy the assessment of need is meant to demonstrate. The circle is the family-scale form of the difficulty recorded in [Axiology Value Theory](#) §7.2. It matters more here than in the abstract, because the practical question is whether any outside party may ever override a family’s assessment of its own needs, and the darshan supplies no procedure for doing so and no criterion for when it would be warranted.

2.3 Families that do not match the nomenclature

The relationship set is definite (§1.3) and the recognition criteria are functional — nurturer is mother, protector is father (JV, p. 84). Between these two commitments there is unexploited room and unaddressed difficulty. Single-parent households, adoptive and foster families, families without children, households of unrelated adults, remarriage, and extended arrangements in which grandparents or aunts do the nurturing all appear describable in the functional vocabulary. But the texts reviewed here do not say so, and they use the kinship nomenclature as though composition and function coincide. A reader in any of those situations needs to know whether the darshan is describing a functional structure that their household instantiates or a domestic form that it departs from, and the sources do not answer.

2.4 Exit from a definite relationship

If a relationship’s expectations are predetermined rather than chosen, the question of what to do when a relationship is harmful becomes pressing. The sources reviewed for this study define adultery as crime (MVD, p. 60) and make faithfulness constitutive of character, but say nothing about separation, divorce, or the abandonment of a relationship whose expectations one party persistently violates. This is silence, not prohibition, and it should not be read as

either endorsement or refusal. It is nonetheless the most serious gap in the account for practical purposes: a framework that grounds obligations in relationships one did not choose owes an account of the limits of those obligations, and of what a person subject to violence or exploitation within a definite relationship is to do.

2.5 Conflict between relationships

The four-step sequence terminates in mutual satisfaction within a relationship, and families contain several relationships at once. Where fulfilling a parent-child expectation and a spousal expectation cannot both be done — a resource, a decision, or a span of time that only one can have — the darshan offers the widening chain from justice to *dharma* to truth as the place to reconsider, but no method for deciding. The general form of this problem is recorded in [Axiology Value Theory](#) §7.7; the family is where it is met daily rather than occasionally.

2.6 Authority, seniority, and the rejection of age

JV rejects age, power, wealth, and intelligence as bases for identifying relationships (§1.5), while the value chain runs through glory — emulation of elders embraced without resistance (§1.7) — and guidance flows from parent to child. The two are consistent if what is rejected is age as a *claim to deference* and what is retained is the elder's conduct as *worth emulating*. The texts do not draw that distinction explicitly, and without it the account can be read as re-authorising the seniority it had just refused.

2.7 Gendered role language

Nurturing is attached to mother and protection to father (JV, pp. 56, 84), and the spousal relationship is stated as husband-wife (MVD, p. 190). Whether this is a description of functions that any parent may perform, a claim about characteristic tendencies, or a normative allocation of roles by sex is not settled by the passages reviewed here. The three readings have very different consequences, and a study meaning to defend or criticise the darshan on this point would need to establish which one the wider corpus supports — including the Hindi, since the English translations may be firmer than the originals.

2.8 The transmission circuit and the family already going wrong

§1.12 gives the darshan a strong explanation of how families entrench error: conduct transmits *kusanskar* by the same mechanism that transmits *susanskar*, and more effectively than instruction. The corollary is that a family already ordered by fear and temptation is the hardest case for the darshan's own remedy, since the child's material for emulation is exactly what needs correcting. The available resources are the natural attraction of lower value toward higher value and glory as emulation without resistance, both of which require a higher value to be visible somewhere. How that visibility is secured for a child inside such a household — and whether it must come from outside the family, which would qualify §1.14's claim that responsibility is not delegated upward — is not worked out. §1.13 makes the problem harder

rather than easier: if the natal family is where the capacity for recognising any relationship is first exercised, a household transmitting *kusanskar* withholds the entry point itself, and the darshan owes an account of how anyone enters from there.

3. Conclusion

Madhyasth Darshan treats the family as the first grouping in which relationships with predetermined expectations are lived continuously, and derives everything else about it from that. Because the expectations are given with the relationship rather than negotiated, a family's conduct can be evaluated against something other than what its members happen to want; because the relationships are recognised through their purposes, the criteria that ordinarily organise families — power, wealth, intelligence, age, fear, and advantage — are displaced rather than merely criticised; and because values are inherent in *jeevan* and flow on recognition, the darshan can hold that no family needs to acquire values from outside while explaining why so many families do not exhibit them.

Two claims give the account reach beyond family life. Need is determined by a wise family, for the fulfilment of values, covering bodily nourishment and protection together with societal participation — which makes the family the assessing unit of the darshan's economics rather than a consumer of decisions made elsewhere. And prosperity, defined as the ceasing of the sentiment of lacking and conditioned on production beyond assessed need, becomes definable at precisely that scale and at no other. A great deal of what the darshan says about production, exchange, and right-use depends on those two claims holding at the family level.

The weakest joint is the qualifier. Almost everything consequential is asserted of the *wise* family, and wisdom is evidenced by the same activities whose adequacy it is invoked to guarantee. Alongside that, the account is silent where practical questions press hardest — on exit from a harmful relationship, on households whose composition does not match the kinship nomenclature, on conflict between two legitimate expectations, and on how a child inside a family already transmitting *kusanskar* encounters anything better. None of these is a contradiction in the darshan; each is work not yet done, and §2 states them as such rather than resolving them.

What this study has not attempted is comparison. The darshan's account of the family is close enough to the ethics of care on relational priority, to the capability approach on assessing need in terms of what people are able to do, and to household economics on the family as the unit of consumption decisions, that a serious comparison would be informative in all three directions. That is the natural next revision, and stating the darshan's own position accurately first is what makes it possible.

Appendix: Quick Glossary

- **Parivar** — family. More than one human coming together or becoming organised, at the smallest scale of the same series that includes community and undivided society

(MVD, p. 55).

- **Sambandh** — relationship. A mutuality whose expectations are predetermined in the sense of completeness (MVD, p. 62); seven forms are enumerated at MVD, p. 190.
- **Sampark** — association. A mutuality whose expectations are voluntary (MVD, p. 61); a different kind of mutuality, not a lesser one.
- **Sthapit mulya** — established values. The nine values inherent in recognised relationships.
- **Mamta** — care. Nurturing and protecting with the pinnacle of affinity; accepting the other as an image of oneself (MVD, p. 339).
- **Vatsalya** — guidance. Continuity of nurturing and protection for comprehensive resolution (MVD, p. 332).
- **Vishwas** — trust. Fulfilling the inherent expectation of values in mutuality (MVD, pp. 73, 336) — fulfilment, not confidence.
- **Kritagyata** — gratitude. Acceptance of inspiration and support for advancement and awakening (MVD, p. 37); first in the value sequence.
- **Gaurav** — glory. Emulation and endeavour embraced without resistance (MVD, p. 335); the mechanism by which values pass between generations.
- **Avashyakta** — need. The desire for adequate resources, determined by a wise family, for fulfilling values, covering bodily nourishment-protection and societal participation (MVD, p. 56).
- **Samriddhi** — prosperity. The lack of the sentiment of lacking (MVD, p. 72); conditioned on production more than needs (MVD, p. 342).
- **Svayattata** — self-reliance. The realisation of prosperity (MVD, p. 342).
- **Sanskar** — acceptances towards completeness, and the tendencies carried forward for evidencing; the cause of awakening of the sentient aspect (MVD, p. 90).
- **Susanskar** / ***kusanskar** — sanskar* under awakening and under delusion (MVD, pp. 94, 315).
- **Apradh** — crime. Ill-gotten wealth, adultery, and hurtful work and behaviour to others (MVD, p. 60).
- **Upasana** — in KD's redefinition, the process of refining and transforming the root tendencies, and the transformation of *sanskar* and essential nature, with sociality naturally contained in it (KD, pp. 30, 37); not devotional ritual, which is the traditional sense the darshan reports and sets aside (MVD, p. 4; JV, p. 9).
- **Sadhana** — used biographically in these sources for the practice pursued at Amarkantak and moved beyond (MVD, pp. 4, 7; JV, pp. 12, 15); not a term the darshan applies to its own account of conduct.
- **Ubhaya tripti** — mutual satisfaction. The terminus of the four-step justice sequence; one-sided satisfaction does not complete it.

Editorial Notes

Scope: exposition without comparison

Topical studies in this collection ordinarily state the darshan and then compare it with Advaita Vedanta, modern Western philosophy, and the sciences. This study states the darshan and stops, for the reason given in the introduction, and substitutes §2 for the critical work that comparison usually performs. The **## Standpoint and scope** section still records the collection's shared frame, since that frame governs how the primary texts are read here even where the comparison is deferred.

Which relationships are “family” relationships

MVD, p. 190 enumerates seven forms of relationship without dividing them into domestic and non-domestic. The assignment in the §1.3 table is this study's reading of where each is ordinarily lived, drawn from the purposes given at JV, pp. 56, 84, and 108. It is offered as an aid to exposition, not as a division the sources make.

Functional and kinship vocabulary

JV, p. 84 identifies mother by nurturing and father by protection. This study reports that as a functional criterion, because that is what the passage states, while noting at §§2.3 and 2.7 that the sources also use the kinship terms as though composition and function coincide. No attempt is made here to settle which the wider corpus intends.

Two definitions of prosperity

MVD defines prosperity both as the lack of the sentiment of lacking (p. 72) and as production more than needs (p. 342). This study treats the first as the state and the second as its condition, which is the reading that makes them consistent and is supported by SB, p. 223. The sources do not themselves say that the two definitions are related in this way.

Where the practice begins, and calling it *upasana*

No single passage in the sources reviewed states that recognition, fulfilment, and evaluation begin in the family one is born into, or that family living is *upasana*. §1.13 assembles both from four things the sources do state: gratitude's place at the head of the value sequence (JV, p. 108; MVD, pp. 37–38), the formation of *sanskara* in the household (JV, p. 60; MVD, p. 90), the ordering in MVD's definition of satiation (MVD, p. 339), and KD's redefinition of *upasana* as the refinement of root tendencies with sociality naturally contained (KD, pp. 30, 37). The reading is offered as a reading. *Sadhana* is deliberately not used for this, because MVD and JV use it for the practice the darshan's founder moved beyond.

The depth treatment of *upasana*, realisation, and practice belongs to *Spiritual Practice and Realization*; this study takes only what bears on the family.

Sanskar and its citation

The account of *sanskar* in §1.12 is compressed from [Axiology Value Theory](#) §1.16, which sets out the circuit and its sources in full. Where this study needs only the family-scale consequence, it cites that study rather than restating the argument.

References

Madhyasth Darshan (primary sources)

- **MVD** — Nagraj, A. [Madhyasth Darshan – Co-existentialism, Part 1: Holistic View of Human Behaviour](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: *sadhana*, *samadhi*, and *samyama* undertaken and moved beyond, and *upasana* glossed as devotional practices towards deities (pp. 4, 7); five statuses and the ten-tier family-based self-governance orderliness (p. 18); behaviour as effort in mutuality (p. 33); gratitude defined (p. 37); the gratitude-to-coexistence chain and ingratitude (p. 38); family, community, and undivided society (p. 55); needs determined by a wise family (p. 56); crime as ill-gotten wealth, adultery, and hurtful behaviour (p. 60); association as voluntary-expectation mutuality (p. 61); relationship as predetermined-expectation mutuality (p. 62); prosperity as the lack of the sentiment of lacking (p. 72); trust and affection (p. 73); the four senses of *sanskar* and *sanskar* as cause of awakening (p. 90); *susanskar* (p. 94); just behaviour as righteous wealth, marital faithfulness, and kindness (p. 102); family as the first tier of the ten-tier orderliness (p. 161); refinement in *susanskar* following enlightenment about the human goal and *jeevan* values (p. 187); societal balance and the three behaviours (p. 189); the seven forms of relationship (p. 190); social responsibility evidenced in the wise family, and family order to world family order (p. 253); education-*sanskar* requiring procedure, teachers, parents, and study aligned (p. 270); *susanskar* and *kusanskar* (p. 315); love (p. 317); reverence, guidance, love, and glory in the appendix (pp. 326, 331–332, 335); trust and justice as the four-step sequence (p. 336); satiation and its ordering of understanding, resolution and prosperity in the family, and participation in undivided society, and care (p. 339); respect and affection (p. 340); prosperity as production more than needs, and self-reliance (p. 342).
- **JV** — Nagraj, A. [Jeevan Vidya: An Introduction](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: *upasana* as rituals in the traditional sense (p. 9); *sadhana* at Amarkantak and its limits (pp. 12, 15); refuge in God as the real father and mother yielding no human, and purpose inherent in all relationships (p. 57); idealism of renunciation, non-accumulation, detachment, and devotion producing no undivided society (p. 105); values realised through recognition of relationships, humane conduct as values, character, and ethics, and character as righteous wealth, marital faithfulness, and kindness (p. 55); relationships studied through their purposes, and nurturing and protection as the mother-child and father-child purposes (p. 56); *sanskar* in children

transforming homes and families (p. 60); recognition of mother, father, *guru*, and disciple by purpose (p. 84); the nine established values, the seven relationships, the six purposes of relationship, and the rejection of power, wealth, intelligence, and age (p. 108); authenticity as highest priority, and fear and temptation as non-values (p. 109); values inherent in *jeevan* and the mother's recognition of her child (p. 138).

- **SB** — Nagraj, A. [*Samadhanatmak Bhautikvad \(Resolution Centred Materialism\)*](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: prosperity through production in excess of needs within a wise family, among the four human goals (p. 223).
- **KD** — Nagraj, A. *Manav Karm Darshan* (Madhyasth Darshan, Part 2). [Working English translation](#); [Hindi–English review edition](#). Cited: no contact or relationship devoid of value (p. 20); Ch. 2 on *upasana* — refinement and transformation of the root tendencies and of *sanskar* (p. 30), aim of all *upasanas* as undivided society and universal orderliness, and immersion in universal values (p. 35), *upasanas* only for capacity-for-awakening (p. 36), wisdom and *jeevan*-value as the direct result of *upasana* with sociality naturally contained (p. 37), *upasana* as education and orderliness in its own nature and symbol-directed *upasana* as secondary and unsociable (p. 42). The translation covers front matter and chapters 1–3 (see its README). The English text is a working translation; quoted formulations — particularly the Ch. 2 material, which carries the argument in §1.13 — should be checked against the Hindi.

Related studies in this collection

- [Axiology Value Theory](#) — what a value is (§1.1), relationship and association (§1.6), the nine established values (§1.7), the four-step justice sequence (§1.8), *sanskar* and the deepening of understanding through conduct (§1.16), and the open problems this study inherits (§§7.2, 7.7).
- [How Undivided Society Is Established](#) — the family as the first field of evidence and the argument outward to undivided society (§5.2).
- [Human Behavior and Society](#) — family-based self-organising orderliness and the progression from person to undivided society (§§1.4.2–1.4.3).
- [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) — the four human goals and the five dimensions of social orderliness (§1.15).
- *Spiritual Practice and Realization* (Ongoing) — *upasana*, realisation, and the practice path; §1.13 draws only the family-scale consequence of KD's redefinition.
- *Education and Sanskar* (Ongoing) — consciousness-development value education, developing §§1.12–1.13.
- *Prosperity Economics and Right Use* (Ongoing) — production, exchange, and right-use built on the family-scale assessment of need in §§1.10–1.11.
- *Governance Justice and Undivided Society* (Ongoing) — the ten-tier orderliness whose first tier is set out in §1.14.